E-CONTENT ON
CLASS X : POLITICAL SCIENCE
CHAPTER:3

DEMOCRACY AND DIVERSITY

DEMOCRACY AND DIVERSITY

Democracy is a form of Government in which people elect their representatives and through that representatives the Government is formed. According to Abraham Lincoln it is a form of Government by the people, for the people and of the people.

Forms of Diversities in a Democracy.

In a democracy power can be distributed to accommodate linguistic and regional diversities. Apart from this sometimes ,people also identify themselves and relate with others on the basis of their physical appearance ,class ,religion ,gender ,caste and tribe etc.

Mexico Olympics Incident of 1968.

Landmark in the history of Civil Rights Movement

This picture depicts an important landmark in the history of the Civil Rights Movement in the United States. In the medal ceremony of 200 metres. race in the 1968 Mexico Olympics the two men standing with clenched fists upraised and heads bowed, while the U S National anthem was played are Tommie Smith and John Carlos . They won gold and bronze medals respectively.

Purpose of the Protests

These two US Athletes Smith and Carlos received their medals wearing black socks and no shoes to represent Black Poverty .With this gesture they tried to draw international attention to racial discrimination in the United states. The black gloved fists were meant to symbolise BLACK POWER.

Reaction of the white athlete

The silver medal winner in the event was an Australian athlete Peter Norman wore a human rights badge on his shirt during the ceremony to show his support to two Americans.

Consequences of the incident

The International Olympic Association held Carlos and Smith guilty of violating the Olympic spirit by making a political statement. Their medals were taken back. Back home ,they were subjected to lot criticism. Norman too suffered for his action and he was not included in the Australian team for the next Olympics.

Positive Effects of the Protest

Their action succeeded in gaining international attention for the Civil Rights Movement in the US. In 2005the San Jose State University honoured them and installed the statue of Smith and Carlos in the University campus as they were the students of that University earlier.

Differences, Similarities, Divisions

Athletes involved in the incident were responding to social divisions and social inequalities. The examples of Belgium and Sri Lanka in the earlier chapter show both regional and social divisions. In the case of Belgium people who live in different regions speak different languages, .In Sri Lanka there was linguistic and religious differences.

Origins of Social differences

1.Social differences based on Birth .We do not choose to belong to our community, male or female, tall or short ,different complexions, different physical abilities and disabilities but we belong to it simply we born in that style.

Social differences based on our Choices

Some people are atheists, some follow a religion other than one in which he was born, most of us choose what to study, what occupation to take up, which game or cultural activities to take part in .

Social differences and Social Division

Social differences divide similar people from one another , but they also unite very different people. People belonging to different social groups share differences and similarities cutting across the boundaries of their group. In the Mexico Olympics Carlos and Smith were similar in one way and thus different from Norman who was white . But they were also all similar in other ways-they were all athletes, who stood against racial discrimination.

Overlapping and Cross-cutting Differences.

The difference between the Blacks and Whites becomes a social division in the US because the Blacks tend to be poor, homeless and discriminated against. In India the Dalit's tend to be poor and landless. They often face discrimination and injustice. Situation of this kind produce social divisions, when one kind of social difference becomes more important than the other and the people start feeling that they belong to different communities.

Crosscutting Differences.

If social differences cross cut one another, it is difficult to pit one group of people against the other. It means that groups that share a common interest on one issue are likely to be in different side on a different issue.

Example for overlapping.

Take the case of Northern Ireland and Netherlands, both are predominantly Christian but divided between Catholics and Protestants. In Northern Ireland class and religion overlap with each other. If you are a Catholic you are more likely to be poor, and you have suffered a history of discrimination.

Example of Cross-cutting.

In the Netherlands class and religion tend to cut across each other. Catholics and Protestants are about equally likely to be poor or rich. The result is that Catholics and Protestants have had no conflicts or discrimination in the Netherlands.

Result of Overlapping and Cross-cutting.

Overlapping social differences create possibilities of deep social divisions and tension ,whereas the crosscutting social differences are easier to accommodate.

Homogenous Society.

A society that has similar kinds of people, especially where there are no significant ethnic differences.

Example: Germany and Sweden some years back.

Disappearance of Homogenous Society.

Homogenous societies undergoing rapid change with influx of people from other parts of the world. Migrants bring with them their own culture and tend to form a different social community. In this sense most countries of the world are multi-cultural.

Politics and Social Divisions.

Combination of politics and social division is very dangerous and explosive. Democracy involve competition of various political parties. Their competition tends to divide any society. If they start competing in terms of some existing social divisions , it can make social divisions in to political divisions and lead to conflicts, violence or even disintegration of a country. This has happened in many countries. Example: Northern Ireland , Yugoslavia

Effects of Social divisions in Politics

Wherever social divisions exists ,these divisions are reflected in politics.

Social divisions affect voting in some countries

People from one community tend to prefer some party more than others.

In many countries there are parties that focus only on one community

Three determinants that decide the outcome of social change

1.How people perceive their identities-If people see their identities in a singular and exclusive terms it becomes very difficult to accommodate. Example: Northern Ireland

If the people see that their identities are multiple and are complementary with the national identity it is much easier to accommodate. Example : A majority of Belgians now feel that they are as much Belgian as they are Dutch or German speaking.

2. How political leaders raise the demands of any community. It is easier to accommodate demands that are within the constitutional framework and are not at the cost of another community . Example : Yugoslavia and Sri Lanka.

3.How the Government reacts to demands of different groups. If the rulers are willing to share power and accommodate the reasonable demands of minority community ,social divisions become less threatening for the country. If the rulers try to suppress the demands of minorities in the name of national unity ,the end result is often quite the opposite.

Diversity Strengthens Democracy

Expression of various kinds of social divisions in politics often results in their cancelling one another and thus reducing their intensity and thereby strengthening democracy. A positive attitude towards diversity and a willingness to accommodate it do not come about easily. People who feel marginalised, deprived and discriminated have to fight against the injustices. History shows that democracy is the best way to fight for recognition and also to accommodate diversity. Example : Belgium